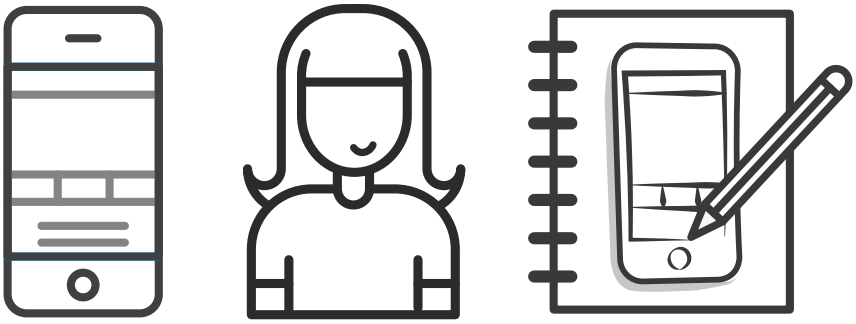

Which Prototype Should You Build?

Prototypes are essential in the design thinking process. They help us test and compare ideas and collaborate with other team-mates to create solutions that solve user needs. But faced with such a wide range of prototypes you can build, you might feel a little overwhelmed. How do you know which prototype to create?

Here are 4 steps you can take, adapted from IDEO's Design Kit, to decide which type of prototype to use.

01: What is Your Idea About?

- With your team, note down the key components of your idea or ideas. This helps you figure out which parts of your idea/s need to be tested with prototypes.
- If you find yourself with many different ideas, that's a good sign that you should start with low-fidelity prototypes to whittle them down into fewer, more effective ideas. Sketch a paper prototype to quickly test and validate your ideas!

02: What Questions Do You Want to Ask?

- For each idea, **write down a couple of questions you want answered**. What are some assumptions that you want to test? Which parts of your idea are you most unsure about?
- Try to come up with both broad and narrow questions. For instance, if your idea is a restaurant reservation app, a broad question could be whether the app solves the user need you identified. A narrow question could be whether a map view is the best way to let users discover restaurants around them.

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- Generally, broad questions are best answered through low-fidelity prototypes while narrow questions are best answered through high-fidelity prototypes.

03: Which Kind of Prototype Should You Make?

- For each question that you've come up with, **think about the best way to answer it**.
- Low-fidelity prototypes are great for getting answers to broad questions and for comparing different alternative solutions.
- High-fidelity prototypes are great if you need to test detailed parts of your idea.
- Conduct a brainstorming session with your team. Decide which questions are the most important, and then match them with the right kind of prototype to build.

04: Just Do It!

- **If in doubt, build first!** Start with quick and easy paper prototypes, then evaluate after you've created them.
- Design thinking has a bias towards action, so you shouldn't spend too much time thinking about what to build.
- You'll often find that just the act of *creating* a prototype will help you figure out the next steps in your design process.

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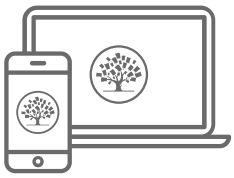

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